

Therapy Approaches

Minimal Pairs

When your speech and language therapist creates a therapy plan, there are different approaches that they can choose. There is no single intervention approach that works for every child and sometimes this may need to be changed. Based on current research and evidence based practice, your speech and language therapist will aim to select the right intervention to meet the needs of the child.



What are
minimal
pairs?

Minimal pairs are
word pairs that
differ by one
sound.



Minimal Pairs Therapy

In minimal pairs therapy a child will be asked to practice word pairs that differ by one sound. Your speech and language therapist will select specific words based on the sound error that the child is making.

What happens in therapy?

- Firstly, the therapist will create a word list and accompanying pictures containing word pairs to use in therapy. The picture pairs are introduced to the child so that they are familiar with them and understand the meaning of the words.
- Listening games will be played which will require the child to listen to the therapist and choose the card that matches what was said. This is so that the child can *hear* the difference between the word pairs.
- The child will also have a go at imitating the word pairs, sometimes the therapist may pretend to be confused e.g. 'Did you mean 'key' or 'tea'? if the child says the wrong word. This helps the child understand the differences between sounds and that it can change the meaning of words
- Your therapist may also provide tips on how to say their sounds correctly.

EXAMPLE:

A child is substituting the back sound 'k' for the front sound 't'. In this case a selection of word initial 'k' and 't' words would be selected that only differ by these two sounds.

SAMPLE MINIMAL PAIR LIST

K vs T

key - tea

car- tar

cap-tap

cape-tape

